



URUGUAY

Capital city: Montevideo
Area: 68,039 sq miles (176,220 sq km)
Population: 3,400,000
Official language: Spanish
Major religions: Christian 68%, Jewish 2%, other 30%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: New Uruguayan peso
Adult literacy rate: 98%
Life expectancy: 75 years
People per doctor: 270
Televisions: 214 per 1,000 people

PARAGUAY

Capital city: Asunción
Area: 157,046 sq miles (406,750 sq km)
Population: 5,900,000
Official languages: Spanish, Guaraní
Major religions: Christian 100%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Guaraní
Adult literacy rate: 92%
Life expectancy: 71 years
People per doctor: 909
Televisions: 101 per 1,000 people

URUGUAY

URUGUAY HAS BEEN DESCRIBED as a giant city with a ranch attached. Half the population of more than 3 million lives in the capital city of Montevideo, while the rest earn a living on the rich lowland pastures that spread out across the rest of the country. The rearing of livestock has brought great wealth to Uruguay, although recently tourism and banking have also contributed to the national income. Aside from a period of brutal military rule in the 1970s, the country has enjoyed a stable government that has built up an impressive welfare system for the people.



CATTLE AND SHEEP

Twelve million cattle and ten million sheep live on the grassy plains of Uruguay, easily outnumbering the population. In the 1860s, the country's first meat-processing factory was set up in Fray Bentos. The town became the center of the national meat industry when a refrigeration plant opened in 1901. Today, Uruguay exports animal products all over the world, and is one of the world's largest exporters of wool.

PARAGUAY

TUCKED INLAND, LARGELY EMPTY, and with few natural resources, Paraguay is one of the forgotten countries of the world. Once part of the vast Spanish Empire, Paraguay gained its independence in 1811. For most of its history, it has been ruled by a series of military dictators. The most famous of these was General Alfredo Stroessner, who governed for 35 years until he was overthrown in a sudden coup in 1989. Today, Paraguay is struggling to modernize itself. The vast Itaipú Dam generates sufficient electricity to export supplies to neighboring Brazil. Efforts are also being made to lessen the economy's dependence on agricultural products.



ASUNCIÓN

The capital, and almost only, city of Paraguay is Asunción, home to about 1.2 million people. Situated on the eastern bank of the Paraguay River, the city is laid out in a rectangular grid, with wide, tree-lined avenues and beautiful parks. Asunción still retains the atmosphere of the Spanish colonial town it once was.

PEOPLE OF THE CHACO

The north of Paraguay is dominated by the Gran Chaco, a vast stretch of grassland and forest. The only people who live there are the Guaraní and Macá Indians. The Macá sell woven bags to tourists.



MATÉ TEA

The national drink of Uruguay and other South American nations is an herbal tea called *maté*. The hot drink, which is rich in caffeine, can be mixed with sugar and aromatic herbs. *Maté* is sipped by straw from a dried gourd, a type of fruit with a hard rind.



JESUIT MISSIONS

Almost a century after the occupation of Paraguay by Spain, in 1536, Jesuit missionaries began to convert the local people to Christianity. The Jesuits, a Roman Catholic order of priests, set up missions and built huge stone churches, protecting the local Guaraní Indians from attack by their enemies. When the Jesuits were expelled in 1767, many of their buildings fell into disrepair, but are now being restored.

Find out more

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